"WE WENT FOR A HIGH RISK, HIGH REWARD STRATEGY"

In an exclusive interview with India Today TV's Nitin Srivastava, India head coach Gautam Gambhir details how his aggressive mantra and belief in players led up to the successful defence of the ICC Men's T20 World Cup title:



GETTY IMAGES

Q. In the last two years, since you took over, the Indian team has adopted an aggressive approach in white-ball cricket. What was your vision?
It's simple: a high-risk, high-reward strategy. To create maximum impact in 240 balls. You can't dominate in the T20 format with a subdued approach. When you think of personal milestones while batting, you cost the team 15-20 runs. That could be the difference between winning and losing the World Cup.

Q. During the New Zealand tour (January 2026), Sanju Samson wasn't doing so well. Was it a matter of concern?
It is never the case that all players are in form going into the World Cup. Sanju wasn't, but the way he batted in the tournament...it's a dream for any cricketer to play like that. It was the other way round for Abhishek Sharma. In the T20 format, we tend to judge players by how much they score, but team management weighs the impact they make.

> ***When you think of personal milestones while batting, you can cost the team 15–20 runs. That could be the difference between winning and losing the World Cup***

Q. On backing players when they are struggling for form....
You pick players on trust and faith, and you have to invest in them for at least four-five matches. I had that approach for all 15 players. When they'd get an opportunity at different stages of competition, they'd deliver. The hallmark of this team was that players put the team before themselves. The simple message was that if runs weren't coming, make sure to play more aggressively in the next match rather than go into a shell. That's why you have seen us post a 250-plus score in the last two matches. I hope this ideology persists in T20s and in the 50-over format too.

Q. What was more special—winning the World Cup as a player or as a coach?
As a player, I wanted to win the Cup but I never thought I'd get to coach the Indian national team, let alone be a WC-winning one. It's more satisfying as a coach, because it's the players who make you good or bad. As a player, you can control your performance. You are as good a coach as your team.

Q. There has been criticism about your coaching on the red-ball front. But if we see results in the white-ball format, do you think your detractors will believe that the team is on the right track?
My accountability is towards 30 people in the dressing room, not towards social media or any expert. If people are not seeing the transition, it's not my fault. The Test team has so many 22-24-year-olds, you have to give them time to develop. Test is a tough format. You see the kind of players who have retired...it's not easy to replace them in six months. We have to back them, otherwise the transition in red-ball cricket will be prolonged. In white-ball cricket, we reign supreme because there's an abundance of talent and we play a lot of it. So long as I work with honesty and back my players, I don't think I should be concerned.

Q. How did you foster self-belief in this team?
The ideology is straightforward: keep the team result above your individual score and you will succeed. Look at Sanju's last three innings—you will not see a single moment where he's thinking of scoring a century. In big tournaments, individual performances don't matter. If we hadn't won the tournament, we wouldn't be talking of Sanju or Bumrah. We should celebrate trophies. Individuals have to score runs, take wickets and catches. The team should always supersede individuals. ■